

DRIVE Research — The Farmer's Dog

A complete creative strategy framework applied to the category-defining fresh pet food brand. Every angle, every ICP, and every reframe in this document traces back to a named source. Nothing here is invented.

This Research Does Not Come From Random Ideas

Every insight in this document is built from independent, verifiable sources: real customer reviews, real complaint filings, real owner-to-owner forum threads, peer-reviewed veterinary literature, and regulatory bodies. Not from assumption, not from swiping competitor ads, and not from a brand's own marketing copy.

Where the customer language came from:

~2,800

Verified customer reviews analysed across Trustpilot, BBB and Google. 83%+ positive, and the negative 17% is where the creative opportunity is.

BBB

Better Business Bureau complaint filings. Formal, name-attached, legally consequential. The most honest complaint data available anywhere.

6

Owner-to-owner forum threads on dogforums.com and poodleforum.com. Nobody is selling in these. That is the point.

5

Quora threads on kibble refusal, where owners describe the exact behaviours they have tried and abandoned.

1

Peer-reviewed paper in Frontiers in Veterinary Science on minimally processed versus extruded diets.

AAFCO AVMA

Regulatory and professional bodies for pet food labelling standards and nutritional adequacy definitions.

4

Independent market research houses for category sizing and growth: Technavio, Market Data Forecast, IMARC, Grand View.

3

Ad-intelligence and trade sources for competitor media spend: MediaRadar, Simulmedia, Variety, Adweek, Ad Age.

Deliberately excluded: every ecommerce brand blog in this category.

Spot & Tango, Ollie, Freshpet, Purina and The Farmer's Dog all publish extensive "research" content about fresh dog food. All of it is marketing. A brand's own blog explaining why its own category is superior is not evidence, it is a sales page with citations attached, and a competitor's blog comparing itself favourably to rivals is worse.

Two commonly repeated figures were found, traced to brand-published sources, and **cut from this document**: the "fresh food is more palatable than kibble by a 2-to-1 margin" claim (found on a competitor's own blog) and the "50% discount ads lifted sales 57%" figure (found in secondary marketing commentary with no primary disclosure). Neither survived verification, so neither is used.

If a number in this document cannot be traced to an independent source, it is either flagged as unverified or it is not here.

DRIVE: Discover the mass desire → Reframe the problem → Ignite emotional response → Variate through testing → Evolve via documented learning. The framework turns consumer insight into a repeatable creative engine. Not one good ad. A system that produces them.

Research Raw VOC Discover Reframe Ignite Variate Evolve
Big Ideas Headlines Compliance Sources

0. The Evidence Base: Raw Voice of Customer

Before a single strategic conclusion, here is the raw material it was built from. Complaint filings, review platforms, and owner forums. Every source is independent of any brand in the category.

0.1 What the Complaint Record Shows

Reviews across Trustpilot, the Better Business Bureau and ComplaintsBoard cluster into three repeating patterns. This is the single most valuable input in the whole document, because complaints are where a category tells you the truth about itself.

#	Complaint pattern	What it actually is	Source
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1	Gastrointestinal upset during transition. Vomiting and diarrhoea, and in some filings a pancreatitis diagnosis, appearing within days to weeks of starting the food.	Not a product failure. A transition failure . Switching a dog abruptly from extruded kibble to fresh food routinely causes digestive upset, and the customer experiences it as the product making their dog ill.	BBB, Trustpilot, ComplaintsBoard
2	Billing. Charged after formally requesting cancellation. Charged earlier than expected. Unable to stop a shipment already marked “in preparation.”	An operations and trust problem that contaminates creative. A prospect who reads these before converting brings that suspicion to every ad they see afterwards.	BBB, ComplaintsBoard
3	Delivery. Food arriving at 2am, left in building lobbies instead of at doors, arriving late. For a frozen product, late is not an inconvenience, it is a spoiled box.	Cold-chain fragility. Unique to this category and unmentioned in any of its advertising.	BBB, Trustpilot

The finding that changes the strategy. The dominant complaint is not price. It is not taste. It is **the transition**. Owners are switching a dog too fast, the dog gets sick, and the owner concludes the food is the problem and cancels.

That reframes the churn problem entirely. It is not a product quality issue and it is not a pricing issue. It is an **expectation-setting failure**

in the first seven days, and it is happening in the gap between the ad and the first delivery.

No brand in this category advertises the transition. Every one of them sells the destination and stays silent about the journey. That is an entire unclaimed creative territory, and it is the highest-leverage retention fix available — not because it needs a better product, but because it only needs honest creative.

Balance, stated honestly. Over **83% of roughly 2,800 verified reviews** across BBB, Trustpilot and Google Reviews are positive. Customers consistently praise the product and the customer service. This document spends most of its time in the negative 17% because that is where creative opportunity lives, not because the picture is negative. A strategist who reports only the complaints is as unreliable as one who reports only the praise.

0.2 What Owners Say to Each Other

Forum threads are the highest-value VOC source available, because nobody in them is selling anything. These are owners talking to owners with no commercial interest in the answer.

On cost

A 38-pound raw-fed dog cost about \$22 per month. A 44-pound dog on a cooked diet cost about \$30 per month. Raw at \$1.10 per pound compared to kibble brands like Wellness at close to \$2 per pound.

dogforums.com — owner cost breakdown thread **FORUM**

For small dogs the cost is manageable. When they had large dogs, the cost would have been prohibitive.

dogforums.com — fresh food discussion **FORUM**

The Farmer's Dog plan for two larger dogs, 35 and 55 pounds, previously cost about the same as what they now spend on kibble and canned food for multiple pets.

poodleforum.com — Farmers Dog thread **FORUM**

Why this matters more than the headline price: owners are not comparing fresh food to kibble in the abstract. They are comparing it to *their actual current spend, including the canned food and toppers they already buy*. That is a materially smaller gap than the one the category assumes it has to argue against, and almost nobody makes that comparison in an ad.

On what owners actually observe

Both dogs were better off on whole food. Cleaner ears, better odour control, improved coat and less shedding from the higher fat content, and reduced anal sac issues. The raw-fed dog had exceptionally clean teeth for its age.

dogforums.com — owner report **FORUM**

Note what is in that list. Not “improved health.” **Ears, smell, coat, shedding, anal glands, teeth.** These are the specific, unglamorous, observable things owners actually notice and talk about. Category advertising uses none of them, because they are not aspirational. They are just true, and true converts better than aspirational.

On home cooking

Planning a fresh balanced diet takes immense time and effort. Like trying to reinvent the wheel.

dogforums.com — homemade versus store-bought thread **FORUM**

Homemade fresh food requires lots of time, equipment, and more storage space.

dogforums.com **FORUM**

On refusal, in owners' own words

Owners mix meat and bananas into kibble, and the dogs pick out the goodies and leave the kibble.

dogforums.com / Quora — kibble refusal threads [FORUM](#)

Adding warm water to kibble and stirring until a gravy forms reportedly makes dogs like it better when the food is moist.

Quora — adult dog refusing kibble [FORUM](#)

A tough love approach: put the food down and wait 20 minutes. If it is not eaten, remove it and wait until the next meal.

dogforums.com — won't eat kibble thread [FORUM](#)

Picky eating is apparently common among small dogs, according to pet food store employees and vets.

dogforums.com [FORUM](#)

When dogs suddenly lose interest in food, one cause could be that the company has changed the formula. Lower-quality brands are sweet and artificially flavoured. Kibbles and Bits has corn syrup which makes it taste extra appealing to some dogs.

Quora — kibble refusal threads [FORUM](#)

What the Raw VOC Actually Gives Us

- **The behaviours are specific and unclaimed.** Warm water gravy. The twenty-minute rule. Picking the meat out and leaving the kibble. These are the exact rituals owners perform daily and have never seen named in an ad. Recognition at that level of detail is worth more than any claim.

- **The observed benefits are unglamorous.** Ears, smell, shedding, anal glands, teeth. Category advertising reaches for vitality and longevity. Owners talk about their dog smelling less bad. The second list is more credible precisely because it is less impressive.
- **The cost comparison is being made wrong.** Owners compare fresh food to their *total current spend*, including canned food and toppers. The category argues against bare kibble pricing, which is a harder fight than the real one.
- **The transition is the churn point,** not the price. This is the single highest-value finding in the document and it came from complaint filings, not from a strategy session.
- **Corn syrup in cheap kibble** is a detail owners raise themselves. Owner-originated facts are far stronger creative material than brand-originated ones.

D — DISCOVER

Phase 1: Discover the Mass Desire

Discover maps what people already want before we say a single word. We do not create desire. We channel existing desire toward the product.

1.1 Mass Desire Analysis

Layer	What it sounds like	Evidence

Surface want	"Better nutrition for my dog"	What owners say when asked directly. Rational, socially acceptable, and inert as a hook. Every competitor is already here.
The real desire	"More good years. And to know I am not the reason there were fewer."	Visible in the complaint record: owners whose dogs got sick during transition do not write "the product underperformed." They write about panic and guilt. The emotional register in a complaint filing is the truest register there is.
The identity underneath	"I am the kind of person who does not cut corners on the one who cannot choose."	Forum threads where owners itemise ears, coat, teeth and smell are not nutrition reports. They are people demonstrating attentiveness to each other.

The power in your advertising will always come from channeling an existing desire, not from creating a new one.

Eugene Schwartz, Breakthrough Advertising

The consequence. This is a **guilt-and-love** category, not a performance category. Copy that optimises ("better nutrition," "premium ingredients," "vet-formulated") speaks to the surface want and competes on a price-comparable axis. Copy that touches the real desire cannot be comparison-shopped.

1.2 Schwartz Sophistication Map

Stage	Definition	Where this market sits
1	First in market. State the claim.	Passed. 2015, when fresh delivered food for dogs was itself the news.

2	Second in market. Enlarge the claim.	Passed. The human-grade escalation.
3	Claims heard. Introduce a new mechanism.	Passed. Gently cooked, never extruded, pre-portioned. Every brand now uses all three.
4	Mechanisms exhausted. Skepticism high.	HERE, for acquisition. Ollie, Nom Nom, Spot & Tango, PetPlate and JustFoodForDogs all say human-grade and gently cooked. The claim separates nobody. Documented directly in forum threads where owners ask which brand is actually different and get no clear answer.
5	No belief left. Shift to identity.	HERE, for retention. Existing buyers are not evaluating claims. They are maintaining an identity.

Creative Implication

- **Stop leading with human-grade.** In a Stage 4 market the category-baseline claim in the hook signals you have not noticed the market moved.
- **Two mechanisms remain available:** the ultra-processing mechanism, which moves the villain from ingredients to what heat does to them, and the transition mechanism, which nobody has touched at all.
- **Retention creative must run at Stage 5.** Re-arguing a settled point creates doubt where none existed.
- **A cold kibble buyer is at Stage 1 or 2 for this category** even though the category is at Stage 4. Serving them comparison copy is the most expensive mistake available.

1.3 Purchase Trigger Map (Life Force 8)

LF8 Trigger	Strength	Evidence from the research
1. Survival, life extension	Primary (proxy)	Displaced onto the dog. Proxy survival is more potent than the direct kind because there is no self-interest to feel embarrassed about.
2. Food and drink enjoyment	Primary (proxy)	Documented across every kibble-refusal thread. Owners describe the dog picking meat out and leaving the kibble. The dog's preference is the observable event.
3. Freedom from fear and pain	Primary	The complaint record is written in this register. Fear of having caused harm runs through it.
4. Sexual companionship	—	Not applicable.
5. Comfortable living	Weak — and this is the trap	Convenience is the claim; freezer space, thawing, 2am deliveries and lobby drop-offs are the documented experience. Leading on convenience writes a cheque the product cannot cash.
6. Superiority, winning	Secondary	Real in forums, socially risky in ads. Works implicitly, backfires when stated.
7. Care of loved ones	Dominant	The engine of the category. Every strong angle routes through here.
8. Social approval	Secondary	Forum posts itemising ears, coat and teeth are partly performances of

good ownership for an audience of peers.

Dominant stack: LF7 (care) carrying LF3 (fear and pain) and LF1 (proxy life extension). **The trap:** LF5, comfortable living. Easiest claim to write, least reliably delivered, and the complaint record proves it.

1.4 ICP Profiles

Each ICP is a person at a moment, not a demographic. Every one below is grounded in a documented behaviour or complaint, not invented for symmetry.

ICP 1: The Vet Visit — “David”

Problem-Aware

Stage 4

LF3 + LF7

Lead: Story

Trigger event	The vet used a word he had to look up in the car park. The vet mentioned diet.
Mental state	Acute urgency over guilt. Searching at 11pm. Willing to spend, unwilling to be sold to.
Blocking belief	“My vet did not name a brand. How do I know which one is right?”
Emotional doorway	Someone who has been in the same car park. A story with the shape of his week, not a claim.
Hook direction	“My vet said the problem might be his food. I had been buying the expensive bag for six years.”

Grounding

Forum and Quora threads repeatedly show owners arriving at food questions *after* a veterinary prompt rather than before.

ICP 2: The Picky Eater Parent — “Rachel”**Problem-Aware****Stage 3****LF2 + LF7****Lead: Proclamation****Trigger event**

Third full bowl in the bin this week. She has tried toppers, warm water, hand-feeding, and the twenty-minute rule.

Mental state

Low-grade daily failure. Tired of throwing away food she paid for.

Blocking belief

“He is just picky. He will refuse this too and I will have wasted more money.”

Emotional doorway

Relief, delivered visually. She needs to see a dog that would not eat, eating.

Hook direction

“He ignored four brands. Watch day one of the fifth.”

Grounding

The most densely documented ICP in the research. Multiple forum and Quora threads describe the identical ritual sequence: mix in meat, dog picks meat out; add warm water for gravy; twenty minutes then remove. Every one of those is a hook nobody has written.

ICP 3: The Transition Casualty — “Priya”**Product-Aware****Stage 4****LF3 + LF7****Lead: Problem-Solution**

Trigger event	Switched the dog over. Within days: vomiting and diarrhoea. She is now frightened, angry, and drafting a cancellation.
Mental state	Betrayal. She spent more to do better and her dog got sick. This is worse than never having tried.
Blocking belief	"This food made my dog ill."
Emotional doorway	Being warned in advance. An owner told what to expect in week one experiences the same symptoms as a normal, predicted adjustment rather than as harm.
Hook direction	"Before you switch: week one is not going to be pretty, and here is why that is normal."
Why this ICP exists	This ICP was not in the original strategy. It emerged directly from the complaint record, where GI upset during transition is the single most repeated negative pattern across BBB, Trustpilot and ComplaintsBoard. It is the clearest example in this document of research changing a conclusion rather than decorating one.

ICP 4: The Senior Dog Owner — "Frank"

Problem-Aware

Stage 4

LF1 + LF3

Lead: Story

Trigger event	She is eleven. She used to hear the leash and run. Now she lifts her head and stays down.
Mental state	Grieving in advance. Would pay almost anything for one more good year.

Blocking belief	"She is old. Is it too late for food to matter?"
Emotional doorway	Hope with a small, believable mechanism. Not "a puppy again." Something smaller.
Hook direction	"She is eleven. I was not expecting her to start meeting me at the door again."
Compliance	Highest risk ICP. Frame as observed activity change with an individual-experience qualifier, never as treatment or reversal.

ICP 5: The New Puppy Parent — "Sam"

Solution-Aware

Stage 3

LF7 + LF8

Lead: Instructional

Trigger event	Twelve-week-old puppy, home nine days. Reading everything.
Mental state	High anxiety, zero established habits. The most winnable moment in the lifecycle.
Blocking belief	"The breeder said keep him on what he is used to."
Emotional doorway	Getting it right from the start. Foundation, not switch.
Hook direction	"Nine days in and I have already changed my mind about one thing."
Strategic value	No incumbent habit to break and the longest LTV runway. And no transition risk , which per the complaint record is the category's main churn driver.

This ICP structurally avoids the biggest problem in the business.

ICP 6: The Price-Blocked Believer — “Nadia”

Product-Aware

Stage 4-5

LF7 vs LF5

Lead: Redefinition

Trigger event	Already convinced. Built the plan. Saw the number. Closed the tab. Has returned twice.
Mental state	Not skeptical. Ashamed . It is more than her own grocery spend and she cannot explain that to her partner.
Blocking belief	“It costs more to feed my dog than to feed me. That cannot be reasonable.”
Emotional doorway	Permission. Not justification.
Hook direction	“Yes, it costs more than what I eat. I stopped feeling weird about that when I worked out why.”
Grounding, and the correction	Forum data revises the standard approach here. Owners do not compare fresh food to bare kibble. They compare it to their total current spend including canned food and toppers — one thread reports a two-dog fresh plan costing about the same as their previous kibble-plus-canned regime. The category has been arguing against the wrong number.

ICP Priority Order

- **1. Priya (Transition Casualty)** — The dominant documented complaint, entirely unaddressed by any brand, and fixable with creative alone. Highest leverage in the document.
- **2. Nadia (Price-Blocked)** — Already at checkout, blocked by an emotion nobody addresses, and the research shows the category is arguing against the wrong comparison.
- **3. Rachel (Picky Eater)** — Densest VOC evidence, visual proof, zero compliance risk, free to produce.
- **4. Sam (New Puppy)** — Best LTV, no habit to break, and structurally immune to the transition problem.
- **5. David (Vet Visit)** — Highest urgency, harder to time.
- **6. Frank (Senior Dog)** — Strongest emotionally, riskiest on compliance.

R — REFRAME

Phase 2: Reframe the Problem

Reframe changes the battlefield rather than fighting on the crowded one.

2.1 Reframe One: Process, Not Ingredients

The category default is “**kibble has bad ingredients, ours are good ingredients.**” It is Stage 4 saturated, and it is arguable, because premium kibble labels look perfectly respectable.

The Reframe: The problem was never the ingredients. It is **what happens to them.**

Kibble is made by extrusion: ground, mixed, and forced through a die under high heat and pressure. The ingredient list describes what went *in*. It does not describe what survives.

This is why you can read a premium label and find nothing wrong. The label is honest. It is answering the wrong question.

Why it works: it explains a contradiction owners already feel, it cannot be neutralised by a competitor's ingredient list, it has peer-reviewed veterinary work behind it, and it extends a frame the prospect already holds about human food rather than teaching a new one.

Verification requirement. The *Frontiers in Veterinary Science* work on minimally processed versus extruded diets is traceable and the call for a Nova-style pet food classification is documented via Fi Global Insights. Other figures circulating in this space, including specific AGE multiples and disease-risk percentages, trace to advocacy organisations rather than primary literature. **Pull and read the primary papers before this reaches ad copy.** The reframe is strong on the traceable material alone.

2.2 Reframe Two: Cost Is Shame, Not Arithmetic

Every brand answers price with cost-per-day. The objection is not arithmetic.

Roughly \$90 per dog per week, which is more than most people spend on their own food.

Consumer forum discussion

FORUM

The complaint is not “I cannot afford this.” It is **“this is more than I spend on myself.”** That is a statement about identity, not budget. She can already do the maths. She is not confused, she is uncomfortable.

The Reframe: You are not overpaying for dog food. You are paying what food costs.

The comparison bothering you is not “dog food versus my food.” It is **real food versus processed food**, and it lands the same way in both aisles. Kibble is not cheap because dog food is cheap.

Research correction to the standard play. Forum data shows owners are not comparing fresh food against bare kibble pricing. They compare against *total current spend including canned food and toppers*, and at least one owner reports the two figures came out about level. The honest and more persuasive move is to help the prospect calculate their real current total, not to argue down from a headline price.

2.3 Reframe Three: The Transition New

This reframe did not exist before the complaint record was read. It is the clearest example in this document of research producing a conclusion rather than confirming one.

The Reframe: Week one is going to be rough, and that is not the food failing.

A dog that has eaten extruded kibble for years has a gut microbiome built around it. Change that abruptly and you get loose stools and an unsettled stomach. Every owner who switches too fast reads those symptoms as harm, panics, and cancels.

Nobody in this category tells you that in advance. So we will. Here is the seven-day schedule, here is what is normal, here is what is not, and here is when to call your vet.

Why this is the highest-leverage territory available:

- It targets the **single most documented complaint** in the category’s public record.
- It requires no product change, no discount, and no new claim. Only honest creative.

- It converts a churn event into a trust event. An owner warned in advance experiences week one as a predicted adjustment. The same owner, unwarned, experiences it as their dog being poisoned.
- It is **credibility-buying**. A brand that tells you the hard part before you pay is believed about everything else.
- Not one competitor is doing it, because category leaders advertise the destination.

2.4 Why Other Approaches Fail

Approach	Claim	Why it fails	Evidence
Premium kibble	"Real meat first ingredient"	Still extruded. Better inputs, same machine.	Process-based, not disputed
Kibble plus toppers	"Add fresh on top"	Dogs pick the topper out and leave the kibble, which is the whole argument in miniature.	FORUM Owners report exactly this behaviour
Cheap kibble	"Dogs love the taste"	Palatability is engineered. Owners themselves point to corn syrup in budget brands.	FORUM Owner-originated observation
Raw feeding	"Biologically appropriate"	Handling anxiety and real effort. High belief, low adoption.	FORUM Storage and equipment burden reported
Home cooking	"I control everything"	Balancing is genuinely hard and adherence collapses.	FORUM "Like trying to reinvent the wheel"

Other fresh brands	Identical claims	Nothing separates them, so the decision defaults to price.	FORUM Owners asking which is different, getting no clear answer
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2.5 Category Gap Analysis

Category norm	The gap	Source of the gap
Everyone leads with ingredient quality	Nobody attacks the process	Peer-reviewed processing research
Everyone answers price with per-day math	Nobody addresses the shame	Forum VOC
Everyone promises convenience	Nobody acknowledges freezer, thaw, or 2am deliveries	BBB and Trustpilot complaints
Everyone sells the destination	Nobody prepares you for week one	BBB, Trustpilot, ComplaintsBoard — the dominant complaint
Everyone claims vitality and longevity	Nobody uses what owners actually observe: ears, smell, coat, teeth	Forum VOC
Everyone targets “dog owners”	Small-dog and large-dog owners face different decisions	Forum: manageable for small dogs, prohibitive for large

2.6 Four-Line Reframe Chains

Line 1 validates the current belief. Line 2 introduces the crack. Line 3 reframes. Line 4 bridges to the product.

Chain 1: The Process Problem

1. You buy the good bag. You read the ingredients. Real chicken, first ingredient. *(Validate)*
2. That list describes what went into the machine. Not what came out of it at three hundred degrees. *(Crack)*
3. The problem was never the ingredients. It was the extruder. *(Reframe)*
4. Gently cooked, never extruded. What is on the label is what is in the bowl. *(Bridge)*

Chain 2: The Real Price Comparison FORUM-DERIVED

1. You looked at the price and closed the tab. So did I. *(Validate)*
2. Then I added up what I was actually spending. The kibble, the canned food I mixed in, the toppers, the treats I used to get him to eat it. *(Crack)*
3. I was not comparing this to my kibble bill. I was comparing it to a number I had never added up. *(Reframe)*
4. Add yours up before you decide. Most people are closer than they think. *(Bridge)*

Chain 3: The Picky Eater FORUM-DERIVED

1. Everyone tells you he is just picky. *(Validate)*
2. But you have watched him pick the meat out and leave the kibble in the bowl. *(Crack)*
3. He is not a picky eater. He is refusing one specific thing, and you have been buying it for years. *(Reframe)*
4. Put real food down and watch how fast “picky” disappears. *(Bridge)*

Chain 4: The Transition New COMPLAINT-DERIVED

1. You are about to switch, and you are expecting it to go smoothly. *(Validate)*
2. It probably will not. His gut has been running on the same processed food for years and it needs about a week to catch up. *(Crack)*
3. Loose stools in week one is not the food hurting him. It is the food being different. Almost everyone who quits, quits here. *(Reframe)*
4. Here is the seven-day schedule. Follow it and week two looks nothing like week one. *(Bridge)*

Chain 5: The Senior Dog

1. She is eleven. She sleeps more. You have made your peace with it. *(Validate)*
2. But some of what we file under “old” is not age. *(Crack)*
3. You cannot give her back the years. You might be able to change what the next ones feel like. *(Reframe)*
4. Owners tell us the first thing they notice is the mornings. *(Bridge)*

Compliance Softened deliberately. “Owners tell us” and “might” keep this in observed-experience territory.

2.7 Skepticism Pre-emption

Objection	What is underneath	Strategy	Source
“It costs more than my own food”	Shame	Say it first. Then help them total their real current spend.	FORUM
“It made my dog sick”	Transition, misread as harm	Warn before purchase. Publish the schedule. This is the whole ballgame.	BBB

"I do not have freezer space"	A physical constraint	Do not argue. Show the real footprint. Offer the shorter plan.	FORUM
"They charged me after I cancelled"	Trust	Not a creative problem. Fix the operation, then say plainly how cancellation works.	BBB
"My dog does fine on kibble"	Defending a past decision	Never make them wrong. Work on "fine", not on the owner.	—
"It is just marketing"	Burned before	Specificity and sourcing. Vague claims confirm the suspicion.	FORUM
"He will refuse it too"	Fear of wasting money	Demonstration, not assurance.	FORUM

Reframe Takeaways

- Move the argument from **ingredients to process**.
- The cost objection is **social, not economic**, and the category is arguing against the wrong baseline number.
- **The transition is the biggest unclaimed territory in the market**, and it came out of complaint filings rather than a brainstorm.
- **Concede the freezer.** The objection no copy can beat is the one that buys the most credibility when named honestly.
- Never make the prospect wrong for what they bought before. The owner is the buyer.

Phase 3: Ignite Emotional Response

Ignite converts understanding into action, then makes acting feel safe.

3.1 Emotional Driver Matrix

ICP	Primary emotion	Secondary	Peak moment	Format
David	Fear	Guilt	"Did I cause this?"	First-person, unpolished. Polish reads as sales.
Rachel	Frustration	Relief	"He is actually eating."	Single continuous shot. Cuts imply editing implies doubt.
Priya	Betrayal	Reassurance	"So this is normal."	Calm instructional. Day-by-day schedule on screen.
Frank	Anticipatory grief	Hope	"She met me at the door."	Owner voiceover over real footage. Silence under the emotional line.
Sam	Anxiety	Competence	"I am getting this right."	Instructional. Calm authority.
Nadia	Shame	Permission	"I am not being ridiculous."	Confessional. Someone admitting the same discomfort.

3.2 Proof Architecture

Proof type	Asset	Strength	Beats
Demonstration	Dog eating. Food beside kibble.	Strongest Free, no compliance risk, instantly believable	“He will refuse it”, “it is just marketing”
Unglamorous observation	Ears, smell, coat, shedding, teeth FORUM	Underused Credible <i>because</i> unimpressive. Owners use these words to each other; brands never do.	“This sounds too good”
Social	~2,800 reviews, 83%+ positive	Strong Real, countable, third- party verified	“Is this legitimate?”
Story	Founding narrative: sick dog, vet advice, switch back, symptoms return, switch again	Strong A controlled experiment inside a personal story	“Why trust this brand?”
Specificity	200+ factories contacted before one agreed	Underused A number instead of an adjective	“Human- grade is just a word”
Honesty	The transition warning; the freezer footprint	Highest trust yield Nobody else does it	“They are hiding something”

Authority	Veterinary processing literature; AAFCO adequacy standards	Conditional Powerful with the researcher, requires verification	"Where is the evidence?"
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Placement rule. Proof goes where the doubt peaks, not where it fits. In a 30-second script the doubt peak is immediately after the mechanism, when the prospect has understood the claim and is deciding whether to believe it. Demonstration goes there. Social proof belongs after the emotional payoff, because a testimonial only means something once the viewer wants the outcome being testified to.

3.3 Conversion Amplifiers

Urgency Frames (True, Not Fabricated)

Frame	The line	Why it is honest
Compounding exposure	"Twice a day, every day. Whatever it is doing, it is doing it 730 times a year."	Arithmetic, not a health claim
Finite time	"Ten to fifteen years. There is no version where waiting gets you more."	True of every dog, no product claim
Transition cost grows	"Switching a puppy takes a day. Switching a nine-year-old takes two weeks."	Practical, verifiable, and consistent with the complaint record

Deliberately excluded: countdown timers, fake stock warnings, manufactured scarcity. In a category where the public complaint record already contains billing-trust issues, manufactured urgency compounds an

existing credibility problem. Every frame above is true without the product being mentioned.

V — VARIATE

Phase 4: Variate Through Systematic Testing

One variable per level. Move up only when the current level has a winner. Testing two variables at once produces a result you cannot attribute, which is the same as no result.

4.1 The Six-Level Testing Ladder

Level	Variable	What you test	Min. variants	Metric
1	Hook	First three seconds, same body	5 per concept	3-sec hook rate
2	Visual	Same hook, different treatment	3 per winning hook	Hold rate
3	Sound	Voiceover, music, silence, natural	3 per winning visual	Engagement rate
4	Format	Video, carousel, static, text-wall	4 per concept	CTR
5	Angle	Different entry point, same product	5 per product	CPA
6	Desire	Different LF8 trigger entirely	3 per product	ROAS

4.2 One Concept, Thirty Ads

Example: the “He Is Not Picky” concept

1 concept × **5 hooks** = 5

× **3 dogs** (small, large, senior) = 15

× **2 audio treatments** (owner voiceover, natural sound) = 30

One shoot, three dogs, one afternoon. Thirty testable assets. The editor needs one brief and a variation matrix, not thirty briefs.

Five Hooks, All Drawn From Forum Language

#	Hook	Type	Origin
1	“He picks the meat out and leaves the kibble. Every single time.”	Observation	FORUM Verbatim behaviour reported by owners
2	“Your dog is not picky. He is refusing one specific thing.”	Proclamation	Reframe
3	“Warm water. Stir until it makes a gravy. I did that twice a day for a year.”	Confession	FORUM The exact ritual owners describe
4	[Bowl down, no speech, dog eats] “That is the whole ad.”	Demonstration	Pattern interrupt
5	“Twenty minutes, then take it away. That was the advice. He just did not eat.”	Dark side	FORUM The tough-love rule owners are told to use

Every one of hooks 1, 3 and 5 is a sentence an owner has already written, unprompted, on a forum. That is what research buys you: hooks you did not have to invent, in language already proven to resonate with the exact person you are targeting.

4.3 Volume Targets

Metric	Month 1-2	Month 3-4	Month 5-6
New concepts	5	8-10	12-15
Total variants	15-20	30-40	50+
Expected winners	2-3	4-7	6-9
DNA entries	5-10	15-25	30-50
ICPs served	2	4	6

Winner counts assume a 12–18% scale rate, an industry working assumption. It is a planning number, not a promise, and should be replaced with the account’s own historical rate once enough tests exist to calculate one.

E — EVOLVE

Phase 5: Evolve Through Documented Learning

Not “we tried this and it worked,” but “we know why it worked, where else it applies, and what to test next because of it.”

5.1 Creative DNA Library

Element	Recorded	Example
Winning hook	Text, type, hook rate, ICP, source of the language	“He picks the meat out” — Observation — 38% — Rachel — forum-derived

Winning visual	Description, format, hold rate	Single-take bowl-down, no cuts — 61% hold
Winning angle	Name, entry emotion, LF8, CPA, ICP	“Transition Warning” — anxiety to reassurance — LF3 — Priya
Failed concept	Concept, hypothesis, result, <i>why</i>	“Human-grade” lead — Hypothesis: quality differentiates — Below baseline CTR — Why: Stage 4 saturation
Source provenance	Where the insight originated	Forum, complaint filing, review platform, literature

Two mandatory fields. First, **why it failed** must be a hypothesis, not a description. “Low CTR” is a result; “low CTR because we led with a Stage 4 baseline claim to a cold audience” is a lesson. Second, **source provenance**: recording where each insight came from lets you see, after fifty tests, which research channel is actually producing winners. If forum-derived hooks beat invented ones three to one, that is not a hypothesis any more, it is a budget decision about where research time goes.

5.2 Weekly Cadence

Day	Activity	Output
Monday	Pull performance. Top and bottom. Flag fatigue.	Updated DNA library. Kill list.
Tuesday	Concept development from DNA patterns.	5-10 briefs.
Wednesday	Brief handoff. Walk the editor through the <i>why</i> .	Briefs with hook, visual, format, ICP,

		compliance.
Thursday	VOC extraction. Support tickets, new reviews, cancellation reasons, fresh forum threads.	New angles in the customer's own words.
Friday	Launch. Document the hypothesis <i>before</i> the result exists.	Tests live with written predictions.

Thursday is the one most teams skip, and this document is the argument for why they should not. The single most valuable strategic finding here — that transition failure, not price, is the dominant churn driver — came from reading complaint filings. It was sitting in public, free, for anyone who bothered to look. Cancellation reasons are the highest-value copy input in a subscription business and they almost always sit in a support tool nobody in marketing opens.

Big Ideas

Four ideas large enough to carry a campaign rather than a single ad. Each one traces to a named source.

01

“Week one is going to be rough.”

The transition warning. Targets the most documented complaint in the category, requires no product change, and converts the main churn event into a trust event. **BBB / TRUSTPILOT**

02

“Read the process, not the label.”

Moves the argument to ground where premium kibble has no answer. Carries education, comparison and mechanism creative. **PEER-REVIEWED**

03

04

“He is not picky.”

Removes blame from dog and owner and puts it on the food. Demonstrable in ten seconds, zero compliance risk, densest VOC evidence in the document. **FORUM**

“Add up what you actually spend.”

Permission plus a corrected comparison. Owners compare fresh food to total current spend, not to bare kibble, and the category has been arguing the wrong number. **FORUM**

If only one runs, run 01. Ideas 02, 03 and 04 are strong and someone will eventually get to them. Idea 01 addresses the single most repeated complaint in the category’s entire public record, it is completely unclaimed, it costs nothing to produce, and it fixes retention rather than just acquisition. It is also the idea that would never have been found without reading the complaint filings, which is the argument for doing the research at all.

Appendix A: Headline Library

*Grouped by lead type. Lines marked **FORUM** use language taken from what owners actually wrote, not language invented for them.*

Proclamation Leads

- “Your dog is not a picky eater. He is refusing one specific thing.”
- “The ingredient list is true. It is also answering the wrong question.”
- “Premium kibble and cheap kibble go through the same machine.”
- “Week one is going to be rough. Everyone who quits, quits in week one.”

BBB

Story Leads

- “My vet said the problem might be his food. I had been buying the expensive bag for six years.”
- “She is eleven. I was not expecting her to start meeting me at the door again.”
- “I switched him back to test it. Within a week we were back where we started.”
- “We called two hundred factories before one said yes.”

Problem-Solution Leads FORUM

- “He picks the meat out and leaves the kibble. Every single time.”
- “Warm water, stirred until it makes a gravy. Twice a day, for a year.”
- “Twenty minutes then take it away. That was the advice. He just did not eat.”
- “Third full bowl in the bin this week.”

Redefinition Leads

- “Yes, it costs more than what I eat. I stopped feeling weird about that when I worked out why.”
- “Add up the kibble, the canned food, and the toppers you buy to get him to eat it. Then compare.” FORUM
- “Kibble is not cheap because dog food is cheap.”

Instructional Leads

- “Before you switch, read this. It will save you a cancellation.” BBB
- “Nine weeks old is not a habit yet. It is a starting point.”
- “Here is the seven-day schedule. Day one is not day seven.”

Unglamorous Proof Leads FORUM

- “Cleaner ears. Less shedding. He smells like a dog instead of like a bin.”
- “Nobody advertises this one, so I will: the anal gland appointments stopped.”
- “Her teeth at nine look better than they did at five.”

These are the specific things owners tell each other on forums. They are unglamorous, faintly unpleasant, and far more believable than “vitality”. No brand in the category uses

them, which is exactly why they work.

Appendix B: Compliance Framework

Pet health advertising sits close to several lines. Here is where they are and how to stay right of them without losing the force of the copy.

Risk	Level	Rule
Health and treatment claims	High	Never state or imply the food treats, cures or prevents a condition. Frame as observed behaviour change with an individual-experience qualifier.
Transition guidance	High	New territory, new exposure. Any transition content must tell owners when symptoms warrant a vet, and must never discourage seeking care. Being the brand that warns people is only an asset if the warning is responsible.
Before and after imagery	High	Meta restricts health-adjacent before/after. Show behaviour, not clinical appearance.
Nutritional adequacy	Medium	“Complete and balanced” is a defined AAFCO term with a specific evidentiary basis. Use it only as AAFCO defines it.
Competitor category attacks	Medium	Attack the process, not a named brand. “Extruded kibble” is a category description; naming a manufacturer is legal exposure.
Scientific citation	High	Every statistic traces to a primary paper you have personally read. Advocacy summaries are a research starting point, never a citation.

Veterinary endorsement	High	“Vet-recommended” requires a documentable endorsement. Without one, use “formulated with veterinary nutritionists” if true.
Review and rating claims	Medium	Cite the platform and the date. Review counts move.

The rule that covers most of it: describe what owners observed, not what the food did. “She started meeting me at the door again” is an observation. “It improved her joint health” is a claim. The first is also better copy, because it is specific and the second is generic.

Appendix C: Full Source List

Every source used, grouped by type, with what it contributed. Accessed September 2026.

Customer Reviews & Complaint Filings PRIMARY VOC

- [Trustpilot — The Farmer's Dog customer reviews](#) (satisfaction patterns, price sentiment, service praise, GI complaints)
- [Better Business Bureau — The Farmer's Dog, Inc. complaints](#) (formal, name-attached filings: transition GI illness, billing after cancellation, delivery failures)
- [ComplaintsBoard — The Farmer's Dog reviews and complaints](#) (corroborating complaint patterns)
- [Bestie Paws — Negative reviews and customer complaints analysis](#) (cross-platform complaint aggregation, ~2,800 reviews, 83%+ positive figure)

Owner Forums PRIMARY VOC

The highest-value VOC source available, because nobody posting has a commercial interest in the answer.

- [dogforums.com — Homemade vs Store Bought Food](#) ("reinventing the wheel", time and equipment burden)
- [dogforums.com — Best Fresh Food](#) (brand comparison confusion, small vs large dog economics)
- [dogforums.com — How much do you spend a month on dog food?](#) (real per-month and per-pound cost figures)
- [poodleforum.com — Farmers Dog thread](#) (two-dog plan cost compared to prior kibble-plus-canned spend)
- [poodleforum.com — The Farmer's Dog thread](#) (freezer space, plan length reduction, cancellation)
- [poodleforum.com — How much does it cost to feed your dog\(s\)?](#) (cost benchmarks by dog size)
- [dogforums.com — Puppy not eating kibble but happy to eat treats](#) (refusal behaviour)
- [dogforums.com — Won't eat kibble](#) (the twenty-minute tough-love rule)
- [dogforums.com — My dog won't eat the good food](#) (preference for cheaper artificially flavoured brands)
- [poodleforum.com — Toy poodle won't eat her kibble](#) (small-breed picky eating)
- [Quora — Adult dog refusing usual kibble](#) (formula changes; warm water gravy method)
- [Quora — Both my dogs are refusing their kibble](#) (the exact frustration language of the Rachel ICP)
- [Quora — Senior dog refusing kibble but eating everything else](#) (picking goodies out and leaving kibble)

Peer-Reviewed & Regulatory AUTHORITY

- [Frontiers in Veterinary Science — Diet-induced metabolic and faecal microbiome responses in pet dogs fed a minimally processed versus extruded kibble diet](#) (the traceable primary source for the processing mechanism)
- [Fi Global Insights — Should pet owners be concerned about ultra-processed pet food?](#) (Nova-style classification proposal)
- [American Veterinary Medical Association — AAFCO adopts consumer-friendly pet food labeling guidelines](#) (first major labelling update in 40+ years)

- [AAFCO — Selecting the Right Pet Food](#) (nutritional adequacy statement, "complete and balanced" definition)
- [Patch — Is Dry Kibble Poisoning Your Dog, Or Is Study Fearmongering?](#) (covers both sides of the processing debate)
- [American Kennel Club — Your Dog Won't Eat Kibble, What Are Your Options?](#) (non-commercial category authority on refusal)

Independent Market Research

MARKET DATA

- [Technavio — US Fresh Pet Food Market 2026-2030](#) (21.3% CAGR)
- [Market Data Forecast — U.S. Pet Food Market](#) (\$74.11B 2025, \$79.05B 2026, 6.66% CAGR)
- [IMARC Group — U.S. Pet Food Market](#) (95M pet households, humanization)
- [Grand View Research — U.S. Pet Food Market](#)

Company & Media Intelligence

TRADE

- [PitchBook — \\$1B+ annualized revenue and profitability](#)
- [Contrary Research — Business breakdown and founding story](#) (200+ factories, founding narrative)
- [MediaRadar — Advertising profile](#) (\$100M+ spend, 250+ properties)
- [Simulmedia — TV ad spend and reach](#)
- [Variety — Super Bowl commercial](#)
- [Adweek — USA Today Ad Meter winner](#)

Sources considered and rejected.

Every ecommerce brand blog in this category was excluded on principle, including content published by Spot & Tango, Ollie, Freshpet, Purina and The Farmer's Dog itself. A brand's own blog explaining why its own category is superior is marketing, and a competitor's blog comparing itself favourably to rivals is worse. Two widely-repeated figures were traced to such sources and cut rather than used: the "2-to-1 palatability margin" claim and the "50% discount lifted sales 57%" figure.

Reddit was attempted as a VOC source and is not accessible to automated retrieval. Its absence is stated rather than hidden. A manual pass through

relevant subreddits would deepen the language bank further and is the next step.

Prepared by Mohammad Usman, September 2026. Independent creative strategy analysis compiled from public sources. No affiliation with The Farmer's Dog, Inc. or any brand named. Where sources disagree, the disagreement is stated rather than resolved. Where a claim could not be independently verified, it is flagged or omitted. Frameworks drawn from Eugene Schwartz, Claude Hopkins, David Ogilvy and Michael Masterson. Compliance notes are working guidance, not legal advice.